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Dr. Johann Gottlob Bock (1804–1855)

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All primary genealogical research conducted by Ryan E. Bock.

Overview

Johann Gottlob Bock was born on 10 March 1804 in Döschnitz, a small Lutheran village in the upper Schwarza valley of the Principality of Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt — the same village from which his sons Robert (1840-1893) and Ottomar (1845-1909) would later emigrate to Kansas. Known in family and village life as Gottlob, following the family's convention of using second given names, he was the only child of Johann Nikolaus ("Nikol") Bock, a licensed herbal-remedy maker (*Laborant*) and property owner, and his wife Maria, born Bock (*e gente Bockiana*) — a name known only from the closing autobiography of his 1830 dissertation, and previously unrecorded in the family sources. After schooling in Döschnitz and at the gymnasium in Rudolstadt, Gottlob matriculated first at the University of Leipzig (c. 1823) and then at Jena, where he completed a medical degree and defended a Latin inaugural dissertation in 1830. He returned to Döschnitz as a credentialed physician — *Doctor medicinae et chirurgiae* — married Theresia Eberhardt (1810-1870) of neighboring Gräfinau-Angstedt in 1832 (Archion: Gräfinau-Angstedt, Trauungen 1826–1876), and practiced medicine in the village for the next 25 years. Seven children were born to the couple; five survived infancy. Gottlob died on 13 February 1855 at age 50, of febrile illness, leaving Theresia a widow with five children ranging from age 7 to 22 (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Beerdigungen 1822–1860, Bild 126).

Gottlob occupies a pivotal role in the family's history. He was almost certainly the first member of the Bock line to hold a university credential and to practice a learned profession, and he is best understood as a transitional figure: a man who converted the artisanal pharmaceutical knowledge of his father's generation into the formal, university-credentialed practice of medicine at a moment when those two worlds were still in active negotiation with each other. He was also the fulcrum between two economic worlds: his father's generation had prospered in the old cottage pharmaceutical trade

of the Schwarzburg highlands, a trade already in decline by the time Gottlob was a student; his sons' generation would find Döschnitz's economy contracted further still, and would leave for America.

Medicinal Roots: Gottlob's Father

Nikol Bock, Gottlob's father, was a *Laborant* and *Gutsbesitzer* in Döschnitz. These two terms together place him with some precision in the Schwarzburg social hierarchy. A Laborant in this region was specifically a producer of laboratory-made herbal remedies. The 1805 census of Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt counted only 29 Laboranten across the entire principality, against more than 600 itinerant peddlers who walked their products around Germany (Wikisource: 'Thüringer Industrie'). Laborants were the makers; the *Buckelapotheker* were the sellers. To be a Laborant was to occupy the more skilled, sedentary, and capital-intensive end of the trade. They held and guarded the recipes, owned the stills and presses, and were licensed by the Schwarzburg state at Königsee.

Gutsbesitzer — landowner, proprietor of an estate — adds the second piece. Nikol owned property outright. Combined with the Laborant trade, this places him among Döschnitz's small village notable class: not an aristocrat or part the formal professions, but a propertied master tradesman with a state license, real income, and standing. In a village of perhaps 500 people, he was likely one of perhaps a dozen households at the top of the local economic ladder.

Gottlob thus did not rise into the educated class from nothing. He came from a propertied artisanal household with significant technical knowledge already in the family, and his path to Jena was less a rupture with his origins than a formalization of them.

The Gymnasium at Rudolstadt: The Fridericianum

Nikol's decision to send his son to the Rudolstadt gymnasium at age fourteen warrants closer attention. The gymnasium was not a local village school; it required a commitment of time, money, and intention that a Döschnitz family would have made deliberately. Even so, sending a boy to Rudolstadt for five years of classical preparation, and then to Leipzig and Jena for a medical degree, represented a substantial and sustained investment. The fact that Gottlob was an only son made the calculation both more pressing and more focused. There was one heir, one opportunity, and Nikol appears to have committed to it fully. The reasonable inference is that this was a household with ambitions that ran beyond the Laborant trade — or at minimum, one that recognized the trade was unlikely to sustain the family's standing indefinitely and that a university credential offered a more durable foundation.

At the Fridericianum, Gottlob would have been immersed in the classical humanist curriculum that defined the German gymnasium of the early 19th century — *litteris humanioribus*, as his own autobiography puts it. That meant rigorous Latin and Greek, rhetoric, logic, history, scripture, and the elements of natural philosophy, all taught by masters whose methods were shaped by the neo-humanist reforms sweeping German secondary education in the wake of Wilhelm von Humboldt's reorganization of Prussian schooling after 1809. The goal was not vocational preparation but the formation of a thinking, reasoning mind capable of independent scholarly work. Five years under masters Hessio, Vossio, and Goettlingio, judged worthy of university at the end of it — that was a serious undertaking for a boy from a village of a few hundred people, and it left its mark. The Latin autobiography Gottlob wrote in his Jena dissertation is fluent and composed, the work of someone for whom classical expression had become second nature.

The institution itself had deep roots. Founded in 1611 at the Schulplatz in Rudolstadt, it was elevated in 1764 by Prince Johann Friedrich of Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt to the status of a *Gymnasium illustre* and renamed the *Fridericianum* in his honor — the same Schwarzburg principality, it is worth noting, whose state apparatus licensed Gottlob's father as a *Laborant*. By the time Gottlob arrived in 1818, the *Fridericianum* was already over two centuries old and carried the full weight of the principality's educational ambitions.

The closing autobiography of the 1830 dissertation — a standard requirement for Jena medical candidates, written in Gottlob's own hand — tells us how that preparation unfolded. After the *Fridericianum* he matriculated at Leipzig, where he spent approximately a year and a half beginning in 1823, studying under professors in Logic, Metaphysics, Botany, Anatomy, and Chemistry. His stated reason for choosing Leipzig first is precise: he writes that blood relatives — the Latin word he uses is *cognati*, denoting kin by blood rather than by marriage or mere friendship — lived in that city. Further, Leipzig was the dominant commercial and intellectual metropolis of the region: the city where the book trade, the remedy trade, and the university world all converged, and where Thuringian families with both pharmaceutical and professional ambitions had every reason to maintain a presence. For a *Laborant* household from the Schwarzburg highlands, a connection to Leipzig would have been entirely natural. Studying at more than one university before taking a final degree was, in any case, not irregular for German students of this era but entirely conventional. The expectation was that a serious student would seek out the best teachers for each part of his formation wherever they were to be found, and only settle at a final institution to defend.

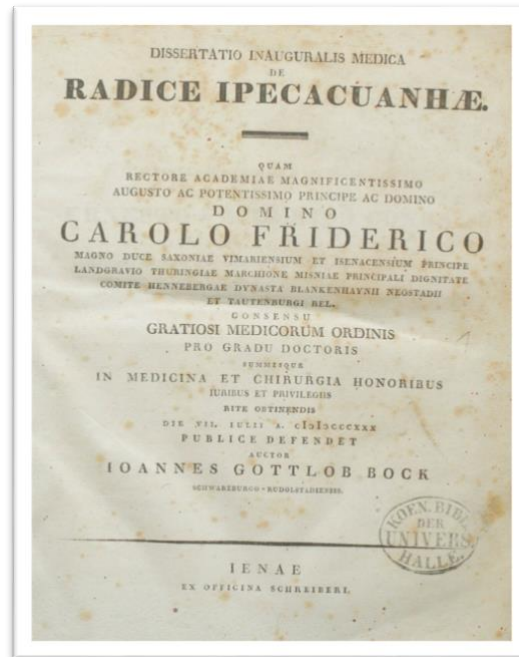
He subsequently transferred to Jena, where his teachers included Huschke in Anatomy, Goebel in Pharmacy, Walch in Pharmacology, Stark in Surgery and Ophthalmology, Succow in prescription writing, and — most significantly — Kieser in Pathology and Therapy. Dietrich Georg Kieser was one of the leading figures of German medical *Naturphilosophie* — the Romantic-era effort to unify chemistry, botany, and medicine into a single natural science — and his influence is visible in the dissertation's theoretical framing. The autobiography also independently confirms Gottlob's birthplace (given as “Goeschnitz near Rudolstadt,” the Latin rendering of Döschnitz) and his father's name (Joannes Nicolaus Bock) — details that align precisely with what the church registers show, and that strengthen the evidentiary foundation of the entire genealogical record.

Speaking of Roots: Why Ipecacuanha?

Gottlob's 1830 Jena dissertation was a Latin inaugural work of roughly 17 pages titled *Dissertatio Inauguralis Medica De radice ipecacuanhae*. Its subject was the ipecacuanha root, one of the most commercially important medicinal treatments of the 18th and 19th centuries (Bock, 1830; K10plus PPN 172738369). Once you know his father was a *Laborant*, Gottlob's choice of dissertation topic seems almost autobiographical. The dissertation's title page, a copy of which is held at the Königliche Bibliothek der Universität Halle (now the Universitäts- und Landesbibliothek Sachsen-Anhalt), confirms several details of the event. He defended on 7 July 1830 (“Die VII. Iulii”) before the “*Gratosi Medicorum Ordinis*” — the Gracious Order of Physicians, meaning the medical faculty of the University of Jena.

That Gottlob's dissertation was written in Latin was not a stylistic choice but a professional convention. Latin remained the language of European scholarly medicine in 1830, serving as both the medium of international communication among physicians and a marker of the formal boundary

between university-credentialed practitioners and the unlicensed healers, barber-surgeons, and Laboranten who occupied the lower rungs of the medical hierarchy. Gottlob's own father was one of the latter. The Latin dissertation was, among other things, the document that placed the son on the other side of that line.



Title page from Gottlob's 1830 dissertation (Credit: Universitäts- und Landesbibliothek Sachsen-Anhalt)

The nominal rector of the university presiding over the defense was Karl Friedrich, Grand Duke of Saxony-Weimar-Eisenach, who is listed on the title page with his full honorific titles: Grand Duke of Saxony, Prince of Weimar and Eisenach, Landgrave of Thuringia, Margrave of Meissen, Count of Henneberg, Lord of Blankenhain, Neustadt, and Tautenburg. The dissertation was printed by the Jena press of Schreiber ("Ex Officina Schreiberi"). Gottlob is identified on the title page as "Schwarzburg-Rudolstadtensis" — the standard Latin designation for a native of the Principality of Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt. The Karl Friedrich named here was the son of the celebrated Duke Karl August, whose court at Weimar had included Goethe as a close personal companion for decades. That connection is incidental to Gottlob's career, but it is a reminder of how tightly interwoven the small-state intellectual and political worlds of Thuringia were in this period.

It is worth noting what the inaugural dissertation was as an institutional form. In the German university system of the early 19th century, it was not a research thesis in the modern sense but a formal public ritual of entry into the profession: a written argument, defended orally before the faculty, that served simultaneously as a demonstration of scholarly competence, a declaration of professional identity, and a legal act conferring the right to practice. The curriculum vitae appended to it was effectively a sworn statement of educational pedigree. These documents were official acts as much as personal ones, which is why the biographical details they contain carry the evidentiary weight that genealogists assign to them.

Ipecacuanha root — *Brechwurzel*, or vomiting root in German — comes from a small Brazilian shrub (*Carapichea ipecacuanha*). It was first brought to Europe in 1672, when a physician named le Gras carried a small quantity to Paris and handed it to a pharmacist there. Gottlob's dissertation records what

happened next: a merchant with a larger supply arrived in Paris some years later, fell in with a physician named Adrianus Helvetius, and Helvetius brought ipecacuanha to the attention of King Louis XIV, commending its value against dysentery and requesting permission to trial it in the public hospitals. The trials succeeded; a second royal physician confirmed the results; and Louis XIV rewarded Helvetius generously and ordered him to sell the remedy openly. The merchant, unhappy to have been cut out of the credit, distributed the root to other physicians and pharmacists, and knowledge of it spread rapidly. For its introduction into Germany as a recognized remedy, Gottlob credits Leibniz, whose advocacy helped establish it within the German medical world (Bock, 1830, §1). By Gottlob's lifetime it was a staple of the European pharmacopoeia — used in low doses as an expectorant for bronchitis and whooping cough, in moderate doses as a sweat-inducer, and in larger doses as a powerful emetic to clear the stomach in cases of poisoning.

This was exactly the territory where the Schwarzburg Laboranten, including his father Nikol, operated. Their core products were emetics, sweat-inducers, and chest preparations — *Brustpulver*, *Brustsaft*, *Schweißtropfen*, *Brechpulver*. A Schwarzburg Laborant in the 1810s and 1820s would have handled ipecacuanha root as a routine purchase from a Hamburg or Amsterdam wholesaler and combined it with locally gathered juniper, arnica, and herbs to produce branded preparations that his itinerant Buckelapotheker peddled across Germany. Gottlob, having grown up in his father's laboratory, took the keystone botanical of his family trade and analyzed it within the academic conventions of modern European pharmacology.



Psychotria ipecacuanha (now *Carapichea ipecacuanha*), plate 251 from Gustav Pabst (ed.), *Köbler's Medizinisch-Pflanzen* (Gera-Untermhaus, 1890). Public domain. Wikimedia Commons.

The intellectual atmosphere at Jena in the 1820s reinforced Gottlob's research focus. The medical faculty had been shaped by *Naturphilosophie* and figures such as Lorenz Oken gave the faculty a character that took seriously the relationship between laboratory work and theoretical medicine (en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Naturphilosophie). For Gottlob, a student who had grown up in a working herbal laboratory, the gap between his father's trade and the university lecture hall was smaller, intellectually speaking, than it would have been at a more orthodox faculty.

Ipecacuanha was not a settled subject in 1830. The crude root was routinely adulterated with cheaper substitutes along the Hamburg and Amsterdam trade routes, making its potency unreliable in practice. Beyond orthodox medicine, ipecacuanha was also the central remedy of a competing movement taking shape just over the Saxon border: Samuel Hahnemann's homeopathy, whose *Materia Medica Pura* (1817) (Wikisource: *Reine Arzneimittellehre*) recommended highly diluted preparations of the root for the very symptoms it caused in a healthy person — inverting orthodox practice entirely. Hahnemann had strong Thuringian ties and his work was actively debated in the small-state medical communities of central Germany by the time Gottlob was a student. The contested status of ipecacuanha in 1830 was not incidental background; it was the context in which his dissertation would be read.

Gottlob did not merely survey ipecacuanha from a distance. In §9 of the dissertation he records dosing himself with escalating quantities of the root over two days and carefully documenting every symptom at each level. At a small dose he experienced belching, warmth in the belly, burning of the lips, yawning, and a frontal headache. At larger doses: violent abdominal cramping, stinging pains in the hip and shin, shooting sensations in the lower limbs, difficulty thinking, and finally vomiting followed by a powerful desire to sleep. The methodology is recognizable as the kind of systematic self-experiment associated with Hahnemann — whose work Gottlob cites directly in the preceding section. This does not make him a homeopath. His conclusions are sober and his structure orthodox. But it places him squarely inside the contested pharmacological debates of his moment, willing to test ideas on his own body rather than rely solely on received authority.

The dissertation also reveals a deliberate professional calculation. It is dedicated to Ernesto Friderico Conradi, the chief state physician (*Archiatre*) of the Principality of Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt — the very principality Gottlob was returning to in order to practice. Conradi controlled medical licensing there. Dedicating his inaugural dissertation to this man was not a mere formality; it was a carefully positioned introduction from a young physician who needed Conradi's goodwill to establish himself at home. The strategy appears to have worked: Gottlob was practicing in Döschnitz within two years of the defense.

Reception: The Dissertation in the Pharmacological Literature

Gottlob's dissertation earned a documented place in the serious European pharmacological literature and stayed there for nearly a century. It appears in two independent reference works spanning 68 years: first in Ferdinand Ludwig Strumpf's *Systematisches Handbuch der Arzneimittellehre* (Berlin, 1855), where it is characterized as *Monographisch* — a term signaling substantive, standalone treatment of the subject — and again in A. Tschirch's *Handbuch der Pharmakognosie* (Leipzig, 1923), the definitive German-language reference work in the discipline, where it is listed among the canonical older dissertations on ipecacuanha alongside works from Jena, Halle, Uppsala, and Paris dating back to 1698. That a 17-page Latin pamphlet by a village physician from Döschnitz was still considered part of the scholarly record on ipecacuanha 93 years after its defense is a measure of the work's importance. Strumpf's handbook was published in 1855, the same year Gottlob died; he almost certainly never saw it.

The Practice of Medicine in Döschnitz

As a *Doctor medicinae et chirurgiae*, Gottlob's credential covered both internal medicine and surgery — a dual scope that defined the village physician's role in early 19th-century Germany. The *chirurgiae* half

of his title was not ornamental. Before the introduction of ether anesthesia in 1846, surgery was a discipline of speed and necessity, performed on fully conscious patients (en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_anesthesia). A village physician in Gottlob's position would have managed fractures and dislocations, lanced abscesses, and attended to the injuries common in a rural economy built on forestry and trade. Bloodletting — the deliberate withdrawal of blood to restore the balance of bodily humors — remained a cornerstone of European medical practice well into the 19th century and would have been a routine part of his clinical work (de.wikipedia.org/wiki/Aderlass).

The surgical dimension of his training went beyond the lecture hall. The dissertation's autobiography records explicitly that in the anatomical theater at Jena he personally wielded the dissecting knife — *cultrum anatomicum movi*, as he puts it in Latin — under the guidance of Huschke and a prosector named Schroeder. The anatomical theater (*Theatrum anatomicum*) was a purpose-built, tiered lecture hall arranged amphitheatre-style around a central dissection table, where cadaver work was conducted under regulated academic supervision. The Jena theater had been established as early as 1629 by Werner Rolfinck, who conducted public dissections there and drew considerable attention in doing so.

By Gottlob's era, the earlier convention — in which a senior professor read from established texts while a subordinate made cuts — had long given way to the expectation that students would work with their own hands and form their own observational judgments; the personal, hands-on session had become the valued mode of learning. Access to the theater for individual dissection under named instructors was not a routine entitlement but a distinct privilege of serious preparation (de.wikipedia.org/wiki/Anatomisches_Theater). For a physician who would spend a quarter-century managing the physical emergencies of rural life, this was foundational rather than incidental. Obstetrics, likewise, was not merely implied by his credential: the autobiography names practical obstetrics as a distinct component of his Jena training, with Stark and Walch as his guides in that field specifically. For a village of Döschnitz's size, the sole credentialed physician would have been the attendant at nearly every difficult birth in the community for the entirety of his practice.

In practical terms, a village physician in Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt occupied a defined bureaucratic position. The principality's *Medizinalordnung* — its medical regulatory framework — was administered through the *Hofkanzlei* at Rudolstadt, which registered practicing physicians. Gottlob would also have been subject to *Armenarzt* obligations, the expectation that the local physician treat the poor at reduced or no cost. His income was thus likely comfortable relative to his neighbors, but not prosperous in any wider sense.

A Grandson at Jena: Georg Carl Gustav Neubeck (1867–1898)

Gottlob's daughter Auguste Aurora Natalie Bock (1836–1898) married August Theodor Christian Neubeck (1830–1870), a merchant of Rohrbach bei Schwarzburg. Their son Georg Carl Gustav Neubeck — known as Carl — was born on 24 July 1867 in Rohrbach (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1848–1867, Bild 131). Carl pursued the natural sciences and in 1898 defended a doctoral dissertation in chemistry before the philosophical faculty of the University of Jena, earning the degree of Doctor of Philosophy (Neubeck, 1898; Frommannsche Hof-Buchdruckerei, Jena). The parallel with his grandfather is plain: both men came from the Schwarzburg highlands and took their doctorates from Jena, sixty-eight years apart.

Death and Legacy

The Döschnitz-Meura funeral register entry for Gottlob, dated 13 February 1855 (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Beerdigungen 1822–1860, Bild 126), sheds light on his final days and cause of death:

Name: Herr Johann Gottlob Bock

Profession: Doctor medicinae et chirurgiae und practizirender Arzt zu Döschnitz, Ehemann

Day and hour of death: 13 February [1855], 4:30 [probably morning]

Burial: 16 February, on the local churchyard

Age: 50 years, 11 months, [—] days; born 10 March 1804

Cause of death: Mortuus erat ad febres — he died of fever.

The cause-of-death entry appears to mix German and Latin, as was not unusual in mid-19th-century Thuringian parish registers. Fever as a cause of death in 1855 is a broad category that could encompass typhoid, typhus, sepsis, or any number of acute infectious diseases; the entry does not allow a more precise diagnosis.

Death from acute febrile illness at 50 would have been swift relative to a long cancer decline, but no less devastating to the household. Unlike his father Johann Nikol, whose wealth existed in land, stills, and licensed recipes that could survive him, Gottlob's primary asset was most likely his medical practice — a form of capital that vanished the moment he died. The professional income that had sustained the family's social position in Döschnitz was gone instantly, leaving Theresia with five children and no professional income to replace it. Robert was 14 when his father died; Ottomar was 9. Theresia, the widow, lived another 15 years and died in Döschnitz on 31 December 1870 at age 60.

Gottlob did not live to see his sons emigrate, nor did he live to see Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt subsumed into a unified Germany. The pattern he established — of pursuing formal education and a career in the sciences — persisted across generations and continents. As noted above, this credentialing impulse extended to Gottlob's grandson, the chemist Carl Neubeck. In the next generation, Gottlob's great-grandson Robert E. Bock (1897–1989) enrolled in the American School of Osteopathy at Kirksville, Missouri, in February 1921 (Lebanon Times, 8 Feb 1921) and later practiced as a naturopath ("N.D.") in Manhattan, Kansas, through the early 1950s (Wamego Reporter, 22 Feb 1951) and likely afterwards in Monte Vista, Colorado. Robert's chosen fields — osteopathy and naturopathy — drew on a broadly similar herbal-and-manipulative tradition to the one the Schwarzburg Laboranten would have recognized, even as they defined themselves against the orthodox academic medicine Gottlob had helped legitimize. And finally, in subsequent generations, two of the family's living members have gone on to study and practice veterinary medicine.

Appendix A: Chronology

The following is a summary of the principal dates in Gottlob's life, drawn from the primary sources cited in this essay.

10 March 1804: Born in Döschnitz, only son of Johann Nikol Bock (Laborant and landowner) and his wife Maria, born Bock (*e gente Bockiana*). Her name is known only from the closing autobiography of Gottlob's 1830 dissertation (Bock, 1830).

c. 1820–1830: Schooling at the village level in Döschnitz, then the gymnasium at Rudolstadt. Matriculates at the University of Leipzig c. 1823 for approximately a year and a half, studying Logic,

Metaphysics, Botany, Anatomy, and Chemistry. He states explicitly that he chose Leipzig because blood relatives (*cognati*) lived there. Transfers to Jena, where his principal teachers include Kieser (Pathology and Therapy), Huschke (Anatomy), Goebel (Pharmacy), Walch (Pharmacology), Stark (Surgery and Ophthalmology), and Succow (prescription writing). In the anatomical theater he performs hands-on dissection under Huschke and prosector Schroeder; he also receives distinct training in practical obstetrics under Stark and Walch. The faculty's Naturphilosophie orientation would have been familiar intellectual territory for a student from a Laborant household (Bock, 1830 — dissertation autobiography).

1830: Defends his Latin dissertation *De radice ipecacuanhae* at Jena on 7 July 1830. Publisher: Schreiber (“Ex Officina Schreiberi”). A copy of the title page is held at the Königliche Bibliothek der Universität Halle (now the Universitäts- und Landesbibliothek Sachsen-Anhalt). He is now legally entitled to practice as *Doctor medicinae et chirurgiae*.

29 July 1832: Marries Johanne Wilhelmine Jacobine Theresia Eberhardt (born 1810) at Döschnitz. The marriage entry describes him as, “*Doctor medicinae et chirurgiae in Döschnitz, des Johann Nikol Bock, Laborant und Gutsbesitzer daselbst, einziger Sohn einziger Eh* — only son of only marriage of Johann Nikol Bock, Laborant and landowner of the same place (Archion: Gräfinau-Angstedt, Trauungen 1826–1876).

1833–1848: Seven children are born in Döschnitz: Bertha (1833), Aurora (1836), Robert (1840), Ottomar (1845), and Gustav (1848). Gustav Eduard (1834) and unnamed twins (1841) do not survive infancy. Following family convention, the children were generally known by their second given names (Archion: Döschnitz-Meura, Taufen 1822–1847, Bilder 57, 68; Taufen 1848–1867, Bild 6).

13 February 1855: Gottlob dies in Döschnitz, age 50 years 11 months, of febrile illness. He is buried on 16 February in the village churchyard.

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Baptism record for Gustav Eduard Bock. 1834. Archion.de; Mitteldeutschland: Landeskirchenarchiv Eisenach > Kirchenkreis Rudolstadt-Saalfeld > Döschnitz-Meura > Taufen 1822–1847, Bild 68.

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Baptism record for Georg Carl Gustav Neubeck. 24 July 1867. Archion.de; Mitteldeutschland: Landeskirchenarchiv Eisenach > Kirchenkreis Rudolstadt-Saalfeld > Döschnitz-Meura > Taufen 1848–1867, Bild 131.

Funeral record for Johann Gottlob Bock. 13 February 1855. Archion.de; Mitteldeutschland: Landeskirchenarchiv Eisenach > Kirchenkreis Rudolstadt-Saalfeld > Döschnitz-Meura > Beerdigungen 1822–1860, Bild 126.

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